universal and invincible globalized order led by the US. However, what appeared then as permanent was a transient moment of American unipolarity, as it was with other powers in history before. Larger competitiveness and political contestation proceeded to return the world to a more natural diversity. In the process, it was discovered that like fashions, the world of politics also has its cycles. After decades of globalization being touted as politically correct and economically inevitable, we are seeing a dramatic revival of nationalism across geographies. Some have been more subtle and gradual; others unexpected and impactful. They are each different and specific to their society, yet part of a larger statement of cultural beliefs.

When Donald Trump rejected globalism in favour of patriotism at the UN in September 2018, he may have typically overstated his case. But the underlying reality is hard to wish away. As electoral outcomes have affirmed across continents, the trend line today points towards stronger cultural identities and more nationalist narratives. Whether it is in aspiration or in anxiety, we are witnessing a return to history rather than an end to it. In cases like China, it is an outcome of newly developed capabilities. But we also see nations like Russia, Turkey or Iran exercise influence without there being an objective difference in their circumstances. Nationalism appears to be the X-factor in such situations. These global trends are reflected in domestic debates where cosmopolitanism is held responsible for the loss of livelihood as much as of identity. And indeed, how nationalism as a concept is perceived tells us much about a society.

Broadly, the West has been less comfortable with it than Asia, where it is regarded as a natural corollary of economic progress. This, of course, has now started to change with the coming of Trump. But there are specific histories at work that explain why Germany and Japan shy away while a Russia or Turkey may flaunt it. China has come to the game late, having used it as a diplomatic tool for long. But for much of the developing world, especially nations that have regained independence from colonial rule, nationalism is synonymous with asserting independence. Whether optimistic or not, polities in different predicaments are now going down that path – witness the China Dream, Brexit or America First. The linkage